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Nicola Mendelsohn, who heads Meta's global advertising business, is bullish on India. The country has a lot going for it, such as the creator economy and messaging, says the Vice President of Global Business Group, Meta. And while the company is exploring new revenue streams, the advertising business is facing headwinds. For instance, Apple's privacy moves will cost Meta \$10 billion. Not to mention Apple imposing a 30 per cent "tax" for boosting posts. Meta has also seen its profits decline in recent times. Mendelsohn, 51, in an interview with *Business Today's Sourav Majumdar and Abhik Sen*, talks about what Meta is doing to counter Apple's moves in the advertising arena, privacy, the creator economy, monetisation plans, and why India is an important part of the story. Edited excerpts:

Q: How do you sell the metaverse to advertisers?

A: When Mark [Zuckerberg, the Meta Founder] put out his vision for the metaverse, he talked about the fact that it's still another five to 10 years off. So, to that end, we're still right at the beginning. And the way that Facebook has operated, the way that Meta now operates, is that we build things for people first. And then we look at where the monetisation opportunities are. I can't answer your question, because we don't know yet. But what independent research is telling us is that over the next 10 years, the metaverse is going to be worth

about \$3 trillion. So it's going to be a huge economy that's going to be created. There is going to be a massive opportunity around creators. They're going to be the people that build it; they're going to be the people that take communities of followers there; [and] they're going to be the people that offer services there.

Q: Will it be easy for Meta to monetise all this?

A: That's not how we think. We think about what are the indications of where the technologies are going. And if you go back, that's the way that we've always operated as a company. When Facebook was first created, we sent messages to each other. Then we went from words to pictures, to video, then we got live video. Now we're in Reels... We're starting to see some AR coming in... and then it will be VR. But it won't stop everything else. It will be a blend of things. People will access the metaverse in a 360-degree environment, but they'll also access it in a 2D environment. So we're focussing from a monetisation perspective on the things that we can do today. The bets that we see in the near-term future [are on] Reels, which is one of our fastest-growing products. Twenty per cent of all the time that's spent on Instagram is spent on Reels... [Then there's] messaging... That's a very big opportunity given that we now see a billion messages a month going between people and businesses.

Q: Are these messages essentially on WhatsApp?

A: Well, it's on WhatsApp and Messenger and Instagram Direct—it's three different areas. And when we think about India in particular, all of these areas are exciting because there's a lot of innovation that's happening [here] and we're investing in that. We've heavily invested in India for Reels. Other countries look to India, as to the examples that are being created here by the creators and also by the brands that are starting to utilise Reels.

Similarly, [this is] true with WhatsApp. India is a WhatsApp-first country. It's one of the main ways people communicate with one another, [and] also one of the main ways that people and businesses are now talking to one another. So, this is where we've been investing when it comes to imagining new ways that you might utilise the platform. If I take our investment in Jio, and our partnership with JioMart, this was a world-first in India... [and] the rest of the world is looking to understand and say, 'I want one of those'. We want to take that example and see what we can do with it elsewhere.